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The sight of cars zooming through the banked corners of the Zandvoort circuit at high speeds is a feast for the eyes. The orange-clad fans who throng the grandstands with their posters and flares add to the spectacle. It is a shame that the circuit will not be returning to the F1 calendar for the foreseeable future.

The last race (for now) in the Dutch coastal town had the fans on their feet throughout, despite home hero Max Verstappen's early crash threatening to dampen the spirits. The early red flag, a multi-stop strategy, a late Virtual Safety Car (VSC) and three teams showing good pace all played their part in an eventful finish. The Dutch Grand Prix result, more importantly, hinted at a change of guard in the chase for the World Championship.

Lando Norris and McLaren entered the weekend on the back of an encouraging win in Hungary. A month-long summer break allowed them to bathe in the glory for longer than usual. The Sprint Race preceding the Grand Prix, however, laid bare the glaring issue of tyre wear, which allowed Ferrari's Charles Leclerc to pip the defending World Champion to second place behind George Russell.

When the teams reassembled the following day for the race, which Norris started on pole, excessive wear was expected to be a major concern against the chasing Mercedes and Ferrari. But despite the chaos surrounding pit stops and VSC incursions, Norris managed to stamp down his authority and take a second successive win. So effective was the Papaya team's overnight solution to the tyre issue that Championship leader Kimi Antonelli, on fresh soft tyres, could get nowhere close to the lead car on 22-lap-old hards!

Fifty points accumulated in the last two Grand Prix races have pushed Norris above Leclerc into fourth in the Drivers' Championship. It won't be long before he is designated a serious challenger if he can ride this momentum over the next few races. There is more work to be done if McLaren wishes to make up ground in the constructors' standings, though, as Oscar Piastri has failed to replicate the performance in the second car, only managing a distant sixth-place finish in Zandvoort.

Meanwhile, Ferrari seemed to have been closing the gap to Mercedes following first wins of the season for both its drivers at Barcelona

and Silverstone. But, since Leclerc's second-place finish in Belgium, the Prancing Horse has been unable to translate encouraging pace into results. And once again in the Dutch Grand Prix, the team's lack of operational clarity came into question.

Through the weekend's early sessions, the team was within a few hundredths of the leaders. Leclerc's second-place finish in the Sprint furthered the expectation. But, when it came to qualifying, the scarlet cars finished four tenths off Norris on pole, putting them behind both their major rivals on track.

The early part of the race was encouraging too. Leclerc and Hamilton managed to rein in Russell after the restart following Verstappen's crash, forcing the Mercedes driver to pit to avoid being overtaken on track. The second stint ended just like the first, with Leclerc hot on Russell's tail again. Hamilton, who had fresher tyres than his teammate, quickly closed up the gap, forcing the team to make a decision. And like many times in the past, it was going to be indecision that would shape the rest of the race.

The faster Hamilton wanted his teammate to let him through. Ferrari instead deliberated for a couple of laps before asking Leclerc to pit once again. The unconvinced Monegasque ignored the call the first time. "Great waste of time there, guys," a frustrated Hamilton said on team radio. Leclerc eventually conceded to the team call. "Are you using me as a guinea pig?" the seven-time champion then asked, with the team not informing him of the plan to complete his next pit stop. But a timely VSC intervention allowed him to dive in for fresh softs and make a late push for the final podium spot.

A hapless Russell was struggling to keep the Ferrari behind on older hards with a couple of laps to go. But another VSC to remove debris on the track helped the Mercedes driver just stay ahead of his decorated former teammate. "We were unlucky Lewis," said Hamilton's race engineer at the chequered flag. But the British driver was in no mood to blame luck. "We weren't unlucky. We lost time earlier on and that cost us P3," he retorted.

Incidents like this have been too frequent for the storied Italian team, which is still searching for a first title since 2008. There is no doubt that it has two pedigreed drivers who can deliver on track, but as it stands, it looks more likely to lose second place to McLaren than gain on Championship leader Mercedes. With 11 races to go in the season, there isn't much time for the Scuderia to overturn the current trajectory.